Forum 1: Programming as Rhetoric

Week 2

Group members: _____

_____

Before class: *Read Programming as Rhetoric.*

In class: *You'll receive a paper with the discussion questions below. In small groups, talk through the questions, annotate the paper with your group's thinking, and compare notes with another group. Before you leave, take a photo of your annotated paper (with everyone's name on it) and upload it to Moodle.*

Discussion Questions

1. The article argues that programming is a form of *rhetoric* — a persuasive, communicative act — not just a technical skill for producing working code. Before reading this, how would you have described what programming is? Has that changed?

2. The article describes five parts of a "rhetorical situation" for code: the problem being solved (*exigence*), constraints (language, hardware), *audience*, the programmer's role, and context. Think of a small program you've written or seen in class so far. Who is the real audience for that code — just the computer, or also other humans? How might that change how you'd write it?

3. Victor Norman's idea of "hospitable code" compares well-written code to a carefully prepared space that welcomes guests. What would make code feel *hospitable* versus *inhospitable* to someone reading it for the first time?

4. The article traces persuasive, rule-following procedures back through history — Vedic rituals, biblical texts like Leviticus — long before computers existed. Why might it matter, from a Christian perspective, that structured procedures aren't a modern invention?

Submission

Take a photo of your group's annotated discussion paper — make sure every group member's name is on it — and upload it to Moodle by the end of class.